Can any such direct connection with the Buddha be suggested for Sanchi, where Ashoka also set up his proscription against schisms? This is unlikely since the Buddha spent his life in the middle Gangetic plains. It is, though, possible that Buddhist monks moved along the network of routes that linked such areas with the Gangetic plains and that, consequently, before the time of Ashoka, Buddhist communities existed in several places like Vidisha and Ujjayini: the importance of the former on account of his spouse Devi, we have noted already. 'Chetiyagiri', where Devi took their son Mahinda before he set out on a Buddhist mission to Sri Lanka, may well be a reference to Sanchi.[63]

If there was already a resident Buddhist community on the hill of Sanchi, Ashoka now built his presence into their lives in the way that he had done at Sarnath, by constructing a pillar and a stupa. The magnificent lustrous Sanchi stone pillar, or at least a part of it, remains *in situ*. Sanchi was one of the two places in the Central Indian hills and plateaus to get a pillar of this kind, suggesting the location had some special place in his life. Sodanga was probably another such: it was where the elephant and lotus capital was found (the supporting pillar was missing). This was close to Ujjayini, with its close associations for Ashoka and Devi.[64]

The Sanchi pillar like the monolith at Sarnath has a capital with four lions and was constructed near a brick stupa. That the brick stupa was on the same floor level as the lion pillar near its South Gateway suggests that this too can be attributed to Ashoka.[65] The bricks themselves resemble those used in other structures of Ashoka's time, while the umbrella that crowned it was made of fine Chunar sandstone, polished in the manner typical of stone monuments attributed to the emperor. The inscription on the edict is a shorter version of the one at Sarnath. Its lettering is poor and the lines are rarely horizontal. This 'slovenly character of the engraving' was, in Marshall's opinion, because it was inscribed after the pillar had been set up.[66] It may also be that the scribe was careless in transcribing the king's